

JOSEPH

Jacob had a big family of twelve sons. Joseph was next-to-last one of the family, and his father loved him most. Jacob even gave Joseph a special colorful coat showing that he was his favorite son. Of course, his brothers were jealous of him.

Joseph had some strange dreams. Once, he dreamed that he was in the field with his brothers binding up stacks of grain. Everyone else's stack of grain bowed to his.

Another time, he dreamed that the sun, moon, and eleven stars were all bowing down to him. When he told his brothers and father these dreams, his father rebuked him and his brothers just got angrier. But his father kept the dreams in mind.

One day Jacob sent his son, Joseph, to go find his brothers who were taking care of the flocks. He wanted to hear how his sons and flocks were doing. Joseph's brothers saw him from a long way. "Hear comes the dreamer," they said to each other, "now is our chance to finish him off. Let's kill him!"

The oldest brother, Reuben, did not want to kill Joseph, so he suggested, "Don't kill him, just throw him into the well." Reuben had planned to come and rescue Joseph later. Before he could do that, some traders on their way to Egypt, passed by. His brothers decided, "Let's just sell him as a slave and get some money."

Joseph was tied up behind a camel and forced to walk through the hot, dry, dusty way to Egypt. Egypt was hundreds of miles away. It was a strange new land, and Joseph would be separated from his family. Joseph was sold as a slave to a man named Potiphar.

One day, Potiphar's wife grabbed Joseph and tried to force him to sin. "I will not do this sin," said Joseph. He ran away from Potiphar's wife, but she had grabbed his coat. She was so angry and shouted, "Help! Joseph wanted to hit me!" Her lies caused Joseph to be kept in jail. Not only he became a slave in Egypt, but now he had been thrown in jail for something he didn't even do.

Even when he was in jail, Joseph stayed true to God. God had big plans for him. While he was in that jail, he had known for being wise and for telling the meaning of people's dream.

One day, Pharaoh, the ruler of Egypt, had bad dreams that confused him. He could not understand what they meant. He asked his advisors and magicians, but even they could not explain the dreams. Then one of Pharaoh's servants said, "I know a man who can interpret dreams."

"Bring him here, NOW!" Pharaoh commanded.

Joseph was brought from prison to Pharaoh. Pharaoh told Joseph everything that happened in his strange and scary dream.

"Tell me, Joseph, what is the meaning of my dream?" asked Pharaoh to Joseph.

"The dream means there will be 7 years of great harvest in Egypt, but it will be followed by 7 years of famine. Pharaoh should choose a man to store the harvest in the first 7 years so that there will be food in the 7 years of famine."

"Impressive, Joseph! Now I know what to do."

Pharaoh was impressed. He made Joseph the second-in-command over all of Egypt. Although he had been rejected by his family, he became the ruler of Egypt because God was with him.

Later on, when Joseph was giving food to the people, his own brothers came to him for help. You can imagine how surprised they were to see their own little brother. He was now ruling one of the greatest countries in the world.

Joseph brought his whole family to live in Egypt.

Even though things looked bad for Joseph, God turned it into good.